AS.050.317.11: Semantics I

MWF 10:00 - 12:30 AM, Krieger 134A

Instructors:
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Textbook and Required Materials:

This course has a required textbook and a recommended textbook. Both books will be put on reserve in the library.

Required. Heim, I. & Kratzer, A. 1998. *Semantics in Generative Grammar.* Wiley-Blackwell Publishers. ISBN13: 978-0631197133.

Recommended. Portner, P. 2005. *What is Meaning? Fundamentals of Formal Semantics.* Blackwell Publishers. ISBN13: 978-1405109185.

Introduction: This course is an introduction to the study of meaning in natural language. We address both the conceptual and empirical issues that a semantic theory must grapple with, as well as some of the formal machinery that has been developed to deal with such problems. After discussing foundational questions, we turn to formal semantics and pragmatics, as well as their interfaces with syntax and the lexicon. Specific topics covered include conversational implicature, presupposition, type-driven composition, quantification and scope, lexical aspect, argument structure, and the nature of lexical representations of meaning.

While this class is not a logic class, we will use and discuss many mathematical and formal tools (especially propositional logic, predicate logic, and a typed lambda calculus); it is important that you be prepared for this to happen. We will help prepare you for the tools that we expect you to use.

The class covers Pragmatics, Compositional Semantics, and Lexical Semantics:

- Pragmatics is the study of communication in context. We will focus on the different types of meaning that utterances convey, and how they arise from the linguistic properties of the utterances.
- Compositional semantics is the study of how sentence meanings are computed from the pieces of a sentence.
- Lexical semantics is the study of the meanings of lexical items, and the principles that govern such meanings.

Assignments and Grading:

This course consists of seven assignments, a midterm, and a final. The breakdown of how much each component is worth is as follows:

- Assignments 50%
- Midterm 20%
- Final 25%
- Participation 5%

In addition to being distributed during class, assignments and exams will also distributed via Blackboard. When the time comes to turn in an assignment you may bring a hard-copy or send it to *both* of us via e-mail. Please give your assignments a useful subject line, preferably one with the phrase "Semantics I" included.

Assignments (7 total; 7% each). You will have regular assignments to complete. You will usually have a few days to complete each assignment and they will consist of exercises that address the material covered in class. You may collaborate on homework assignments, but note who you worked with.

Midterm (20%). The midterm will be assigned approximately half way through the course. It will be a "take-home" exam that will, in many ways, be similar to an extended homework assignment. The midterm is *not* collaborative. You should complete it on your own and if your require assistance or clarification, you may contact one of the instructors.

Final Exam (25%). The final exam will be given at the end of the course. You may *not* collaborate on this assignment. Compete it on your own. If you require assistance or clarification, please contact one of the instructors.

Participation (5%). We ask that you please take an active role in your education and participate during class. This involves asking questions, attending class, and being respectful of your peers.

Required Syllabus Policy Statements:

Johns Hopkins Policies and Support Services This course is governed by the policies set forth in The Johns Hopkins University Undergraduate Student Handbook, which contains information on a wide variety of topics, such as support services, and policies relating to student rights and responsibilities. This course is governed by the policies set forth in this document.

Some JHU student support services you may find useful include:

Library E-Reserves http://www.library.jhu.edu/services/forms/reserves.html reserves@jhu.edu

Summer & Intersession Programs 3505 N. Charles Street, Suite 101 410-516-4548 http://www.jhu.edu/intersession

Classroom Accomodations for Students With Disabilities. If you are a student with a documented disability who requires an academic adjustment, auxiliary aid or other similar accommodations, please contact The Office of Student Disability Services at studentdisabilityservices@jhu.edu, call 410-516-4720 or visit 385 Garland Hall.

Statement of Diversity and Inclusion. Johns Hopkins University is a community committed to sharing values of diversity and inclusion in order to achieve and sustain excellence. We believe excellence is best promoted by being a diverse group of students, faculty and staff who are committed to creating a climate of mutual respect that is supportive of one another's success. Through its curricula and clinical experiences, we purposefully support the University's goal of diversity, and in particular, work toward an ultimate outcome of best serving the needs of students. Faculty and candidates are expected to demonstrate an understanding of diversity as it relates to planning, instruction, management, and assessment.

A Word on Ethics. The strength of the university depends on academic and personal integrity. In this course, you must be honest and truthful. Ethical violations include cheating on exams, plagiarism, reuse of assignments, improper use of the Internet and electronic devices, unauthorized collaboration, alteration of graded assignments, forgery and falsification, lying, facilitating academic dishonesty, and unfair competition.

Report any violations you witness to the instructor.

Bibliography and Suggested Readings

1. Bach, Emmon. 1986. The algebra of events. Linguistics and Philosophy 9:5-16.
2. Barwise, Jon, and Robin Cooper. 1981. Generalized quantifiers and natural language. Linguistics and Philosophy 4:159âĂŞ219.
3. Dowty, David. 1979. Word meaning and Montague grammar. D. Reidel Publishing Company.
4. Dowty, David. 1991. Thematic proto-roles and argument selection. Language 67:547âĂŞ619.
5. Gamut, L.T.F. 1990. Logic, language, and meaning volume 1: Introduction to logic. University of Chicago Press.
6. Grice, H. Paul. 1975. Logic and conversation. In Syntax and semantics 3: Speech acts, ed. Peter Cole and Jerry Morgan, 41-58. Academic Press.
7. Heim, Irene, and Angelika Kratzer. 1998. Semantics in generative grammar. Oxford: Wiley-Blackwell.
8. Levin, Beth, and Malka Rappaport Hovav. 2005. Argument realization. Cambridge University Press.
9. Ludlow, Peter, ed. 1997. Readings in the philosophy of language. MIT Press.
10. Matsumoto, Yo. 1996. The conversational condition on Horn scales. Linguistics and Philosophy 13:21-60.
11. Parsons, Terence. 1990. Events in the semantics of English. Cambridge, MA: MIT Press.
12. Portner, Paul, and Barbara Partee, ed. 2002. Formal semantics: the essential readings. Blackwell Publishing.
13. Rappaport-Hovav, M., and Beth Levin. 1998. Building verb meanings. In The projection of arguments: lexical and compositional factors, ed. M. Butts and W. Geuder, 97-134. CSLI Publications.
14. Sauerland, Uli. 2004. Scalar implicatures in complex sentences. Linguistics and Philosophy 27:367-91.

Course Schedule

	Topics	Readings	Assignments
W: 5/29	Introduction to semantics; truth and truth conditions; set theory and functions; varieties of meaning: entailments, implicature, presupposition	HK ch1; P ch1	#1 out
F: 5/31	Compositionality, type theory, and lambda notation; …	HK ch1-3	#1 due, #2 out
M: 6/3	Syntax, linking, proto-roles	HK ch3; Dowty 1991; Levin and Rappaport-Hovav 2005	
W: 6/5	Modification	HK ch4; P ch3-4	#2 due, #3 out
F: 6/7	Definite and indefinite descriptions	HK ch4	Midterm out
M: 6/10	Grice, advertising		#3 due, #4 out
W: 6/12	Scalar implicatures; Presupposition projection	Karttunen 1973	Midterm due
F: 6/14	Relative clauses, variables; pronouns	HK ch5, ch 9 P ch3.3, 4.3, ch5, 10	#4 due, #5 out
M: 6/17	Quantification	HK ch6-8; P 6	
W: 6/19	Quantification		#5 due, #6 out
F: 6/21	Event semantics, tense	Dowty 1979; Bach 1986; P ch8	Final out
M: 6/24	Possible world semantics	P ch7-8	#6 due, #7 out
W: 6/26	Verbal alternations	Rappaport-Hovav and Levin 1998	
F: 6/28	Review and summary		#7 due, Final due 7/1